

INTERVIEW

# "The SRK I know at the current moment is at inner peace"

**In her first interview since *Pathaan* became a box-office sensation, Deepika Padukone speaks about her bond with Shah Rukh Khan, the qualities they share and the reason for *Pathaan*'s success. Excerpts from an exclusive interview**

**Q. Your cinematic journey started with *Om Shanti Om* [in 2007], which was produced by Shah Rukh and in which he acted as well. He has been part of your biggest highs—*Om Shanti Om*, *Chennai Express* and now *Pathaan*. What bond do you share with him?**

**A.** It's hard to articulate what makes it so special. It is built on respect, trust, love, security and vulnerability. The magic that people feel when we are together on screen is obviously the magic he and I feel too. It stems from my gratitude to him. Fifteen years ago, a superstar like him showed immense faith in a rank newcomer, who had no experience or lineage in the film industry, and cast me opposite him without an audition, mind you, that too in a double role. The beautiful part of our relationship is that one handhold or one hug communicates everything that we need to convey to each other.

**Q. How much has he evolved in the past 15 years?**

**A.** The SRK I know at the current moment is at inner peace. That is something for the younger generation to learn—patience.

**Q. At the only media event for *Pathaan*, Shah Rukh said how during the film's making, he could sense how everybody wanted "*ki yeh film SRK ke liye achchhi ho* [Pathaan does well for Khan]". Is that something the cast and crew were conscious of?**

**A.** Everyone came from the same place of wanting this man,